first time defined categories. The article was reportedly "rejected by the editor of an inauspicious journal as 'more devoid of content than any I have read,' to which Mac Lane is said to have replied, 'That's the point'" [**7**, p. 362]. Eventually they managed to publish it in the *Transactions of the American Mathematical Society.* This involved a fair amount of wheeling and dealing. "Eilenberg, who knew the editor well, persuaded him to choose as referee a young mathematician", Mac Lane recalled, "one whom we could influence because he was then a junior member of the Applied Mathematics Group at Columbia University (war research), where Eilenberg and I were then also members, and I was Director" [**37**, p. 5983]. The article openly declared Eilenberg and Mac Lane's ambitious goals. "In a metamathematical sense our theory provides general concepts applicable to all branches of mathematics", they wrote, "and so contributes to the current trend towards uniform treatment of different mathematical disciplines" [**12**, p. 236].

The wide recognition of the power of Eilenberg and Mac Lane's ideas was a bit slow to come. Years passed before the words *category* and *functor* "could be pronounced unapologetically in diverse mathematical company" (Freyd in [**6**, p. 1351]). Luckily, the Air Force Office of Scientific Research became an important sponsor of research and conferences on category theory — an unexpected benefit of Mac Lane and Eilenberg's wartime work. Only by the mid-1960s did the Air Force eventually figure out that category theory was too abstract to bring any tangible improvements to air combat and discontinued its support [**33**, p. 239].

Category theory itself underwent quite a transformation after the initial insight. As Mac Lane recalled, when the 1945 paper came out, Eilenberg declared that "this would be the only paper necessary on the subject. It turned out that he was wrong" [**33**, p. 209]. Eilenberg and Mac Lane originally thought that the very concept of a category was "essentially an auxiliary one; our basic concepts are essentially those of a functor and of a natural transformation". They even suggested dropping the category concept altogether and adopting "an even more intuitive standpoint", according to which a functor "is not defined over the category of 'all' groups, but for each particular pair